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POWER PLAY **Politics**

Rob Bonta had a tough week. Is more bad news ahead for California's AG?

Plus: Danny Sauter introduces his own historic district, PG&E uses a bee to fight public power, and a spicy Flock vote tonight.



California Attorney General Rob Bonta is in the hot seat.

By [Dustin Gardiner](#), [Omar Rashad](#), and [Gabriel Lorenzo Greschler](#)

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Dear Power Play readers, as the election nears, we're kicking into high gear. We will add a once-a-week special newsletter, Election Insider, to our schedule, launching Oct. 6. Power Play readers will be automatically signed up. Keep an eye out for details soon.

A week ago, **Rob Bonta** was a hero on the progressive left for fighting the merger of Paramount Skydance and Warner Bros. Discovery — and thereby resisting media consolidation at the hands of the conservative Ellison family. The California attorney general had gone so far as to call it “blackmail” when Paramount threatened to leave the state if the deal were blocked.

But Bonta's announcement of a settlement this week, allowing the deal to proceed, is drawing more eyerolls than applause from some corners of the Democratic party and organized labor. Combined with his connections to Oakland political and business figures who are going on trial next month for corruption, this fall is looking like a rough stretch for Bonta.

The Paramount deal has faced criticism from labor leaders and Democrats who hoped Bonta, a progressive from the Bay Area, would extract more concessions from CEO **David Ellison**, son of billionaire Oracle founder **Larry Ellison**, a close ally of President **Donald Trump**.

Bonta said Monday that the settlement would resolve antitrust concerns. His endorsement was hardly ringing, however: “Let me be clear: This settlement is not a vote of support for this merger,” Bonta said. “But we believe this settlement ... protects competition and consumer choice and puts workers' needs, concerns, and futures first.”

Fellow progressives appeared to share the lack of enthusiasm. Massachusetts Sen. **Elizabeth Warren** called the settlement a “disastrous outcome” that will eliminate jobs. The Block the Merger coalition, an industry group that includes liberal actors like **Mark Ruffalo**, **Jane Fonda**, and **Bryan Cranston**, said it was a bad outcome for the “future of film, entertainment, independent journalism, and a strong democracy.”

More establishment Democrats, including Gov. **Gavin Newsom**, gubernatorial candidate **Xavier Becerra**, and Los Angeles Mayor **Karen Bass**, have praised the settlement as a

move that could prevent the exodus of more film productions from Hollywood and California.

But the mixed reviews come as Bonta's name is likely to be evoked in a series of messy headlines out of the Oakland trial.

Bonta won't be in the courtroom as former Oakland Mayor **Sheng Thao** and members of the Duong family, who own a Bay Area trash-hauling company, stand trial on corruption charges. (Thao and the Duongs deny any wrongdoing.) But Bonta has close connections to the defendants, and his campaign previously said he had been approached by federal investigators as a "possible victim" in the case.

Moreover, Bonta has had a difficult time explaining why he spent \$500,000 in campaign funds on legal services amid the bribery investigation. Additionally, he gave away \$155,100 in contributions that he received from the Duongs and their business partners.

Bonta has downplayed his ties to **Andy Duong**, son of the owner of California Waste Solutions, despite social media posts that show them in the back of a limousine with his wife, Assemblymember **Mia Bonta**, and sitting courtside together at a Warriors game.

"Bonta did what any public official should do when federal investigators approached him as a possible victim: He stepped up to help," said **Jonathan Underland**, a spokesperson for Bonta's reelection campaign. "That was in 2024. Since then he's been focused on the fight to protect working families."

Still, Bonta likely faces a difficult stretch ahead, despite otherwise having a good year leading California's legal resistance to Trump and celebrating a historic settlement with Meta over child-safety concerns. — *Dustin Gardiner*

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NORTH BEACH DÉJÀ VU: Supervisor **Danny Sauter** is introducing a proposal to create a historic district in North Beach. But wait, that's been done before, right?

Sure, but a proposal in front of the State Historical Resources Commission hasn't advanced all year. It was criticized for blocking new housing in North Beach (supporters say it does not), and Mayor **Daniel Lurie** lobbied to delay it after an outcry from housing advocates.

The dormant proposal would've put more than 600 buildings under a historic designation. Under Sauter's proposal, which he introduced this week, the designation would apply to only 200 buildings.

"Our local district will protect historic buildings and honor their history without including garages or empty lots, like the state proposal does," Sauter said at Tuesday's Board of Supervisors meeting.

A Lurie spokesperson said historic designations shouldn't be used to block housing construction, adding that Sauter's plan "will protect what makes North Beach special while allowing us to build the homes San Franciscans need."

Former Supervisor **Aaron Peskin**, whose wife, **Nancy Shanahan**, was a leader of the initial historic district effort, told Power Play it's "absolute hogwash" to say the proposal would've prevented or blocked new housing in North Beach. "It is not true," Peskin said. — *Omar Rashad*

FLOCK O'CLOCK (AGAIN): The San Francisco Democratic Party is slated to take sides on Flock at its meeting Wednesday night. But this time, there's a competing resolution to

Gordon Mar's proposal.

Mar said his resolution was stalled by an internal Democratic Party committee chaired by a Flock employee. His proposal calls on the San Francisco Police Department to suspend its use of Flock cameras if it cannot demonstrate it can cut off access to federal and out-of-state law enforcement agencies.

A competing resolution, authored by Supervisor **Matt Dorsey** and DCCC Chair **Nancy Tung**, urges the continued use of Flock cameras.

Mar told Power Play he was surprised to see the competing resolution.

“If a vendor’s national platform architecture enables third-party or federal back doors, updating local policy guidelines isn’t enough,” Mar said. “We need contractual teeth, independent forensic audits, and a willingness to pause contracts when state sanctuary laws are breached.”

Keep an eye out for our Flock coverage to follow. — O.R.

UN-BEE-LIEVABLE: A bee — specifically, Crotch’s bumblebee, or *Bombus crotchii* — was cited Tuesday by Pacific Gas & Electric in arguments against the city taking over its assets. The utility argued that the city didn’t do its due diligence, declaring the bees absent from municipal power construction sites without surveying for them. City officials disputed this.

It garnered quite a few chuckles at the Board of Supervisors after **Bilal Mahmood** highlighted the insect’s inclusion in PG&E’s appeal to an environmental impact review. “I thought it was ridiculous,” Mahmood told Power Play. “[PG&E’s] intention is to delay, delay, delay.”

Supervisors unanimously rejected the appeal, with Dorsey and **Myrna Melgar** sharing some strong feelings. “Of all the gears PG&E could choose to gum up ... to come into this board chamber and to waste our time with its expensive and dilatory stunts, demonstrates a contempt for this body and this city that is, in my view, breathtaking. But neither is it surprising,” Dorsey said. Melgar also had choice words: “I have sat through I don’t even

know how many [environmental impact review hearings] and EIR appeals in the five years I spent at the Planning Commission, and now six years on this board. ... I think that this appeal argument is the most ridiculous I've seen, actually.” — *Gabriel Greschler*



Rep. Nancy Pelosi and Sen. Adam Schiff appear at a Capitol Hill event celebrating the launch of Pelosi's institute at UC Berkeley. | Courtesy Nancy Pelosi Institute for Representative Democracy

PROFESSOR PELOSI: Rep. **Nancy Pelosi's** Institute for Representative Democracy at UC Berkeley held its first gathering late last week on Capitol Hill, offering a glimpse into her next act as she prepares to leave office later this year.

The two-day event focused on Pelosi's mission to defend democracy and the Constitution (which she often says are under assault by Trump). Speakers included House Minority Leader **Hakeem Jeffries**, presidential biographer **Jon Meacham**, UC Berkeley Chancellor **Rich Lyons**, former Attorney General **Eric Holder**, historian **Ron Chernow**, San Diego Rep. **Sara Jacobs**, Maryland Rep. **Jamie Raskin**, and Florida Rep. **Maxwell Frost**.

The theme and Pelosi’s list of high-profile guests is a preview of how she aims to use the institute to remain a force in U.S. politics. As part of the event, Pelosi also led 90 Berkeley students, faculty, and staff on a tour of the Capitol. — *D.G.*

ICE ARREST FALLOUT: Lurie on Wednesday sent a letter to a federal judge urging him to release **Ho-Yin Mo**, a Democratic legislative staffer who was detained by federal immigration authorities last week at the Las Vegas airport. Lurie joined a chorus of Bay Area elected officials calling for Mo’s release.

“In his role, he serves the San Francisco community, and he does so with great care and commitment,” Lurie wrote. “He is a positive addition to our city. ... He is a contributing member of society, and I do not believe he poses as a danger or threat to anyone.”

Mo, a field representative for Assemblymember **Catherine Stefani**, remained in Department of Homeland Security custody as of Wednesday afternoon, facing possible deportation to Hong Kong. A DHS spokesperson said Mo entered the U.S. in 2020 "on a temporary basis but illegally overstayed his welcome," but Stefani has insisted he is a legal employee of her office.

Other Democratic politicians calling for Mo’s release include Rep. **Kevin Mullin** and all 11 members of the San Francisco Board of Supervisors.

But Republicans have seized on the case, and the Trump administration on Wednesday implied that Stefani had inappropriately hired Mo. “Radical Democrats continue to prioritize illegal aliens over American citizens — even employing illegal aliens to work in their political offices,” said White House spokesperson **Lauren Bis**. — *D.G.*

More about the authors



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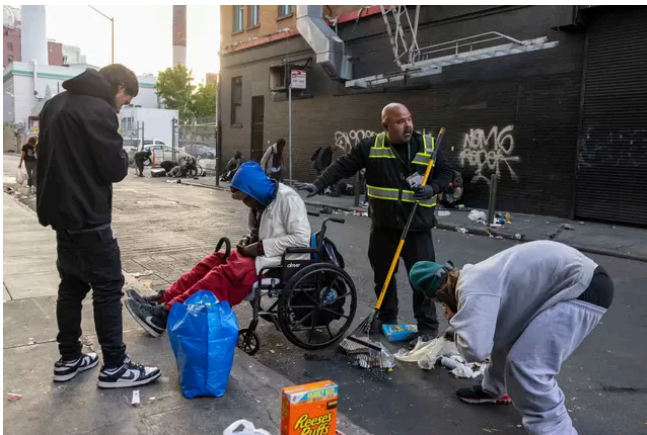
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By [Dustin Gardiner](#)

SF assemblymember's aide detained by ICE, faces deportation to Hong Kong

Catherine Stefani called for the release of Ho-Yin Mo, who was arrested last week during an enforcement operation at the Las Vegas airport.

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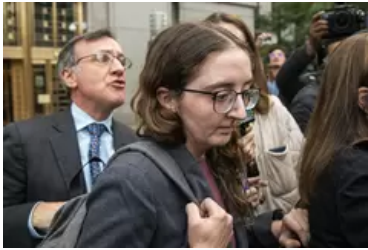
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